

Quiet Post

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COVER STORY

BROCCOLI MUSHROOM ORZO BAKE

She was sitting on the edge of the pool, waiting for her turn at swim lessons and was completely sauged into her swimsuit.

Sara Forte · Sprouted Kitchen

Her longer body stretching the length of the bathing suit so that the chest of it was too low and the straps looked stressed. Beautiful, tender, winter skin against that mustard yellow daisy print. Cleo waves at me, looking like such a... girl.

She turned six a few weeks ago and while we are dancing in the kitchen to the Encanto soundtrack and mixing up our “b’s” and “d’s”, our conversations are about friendships at school and what happens when you die. She is both little and big to me. Motherhood is a wild whiplash. Each one of those days, while the bathing suit became too small, felt like nothing, but is also the compilation of so many small moments. I’m having a bit of a time with my own insecurities and watching them find their way at school and with people. My kids growth, tangled up and digested through my own. It’s just like the moms before me said, the challenges never go away, they just change. I see this girl of mine growing, still needing me, but also moving towards my role as support, instead of the lead. Yessss, I know she’s young, but I can see it. A small shift, the ones you can miss if you’re not paying attention.

January used to be a month of goals all organized on paper - less sugar and new tennis shoes to get moving but this one felt... observant. Curious. Asking what I want, and what my family needs, as opposed to the more/better mentality that a new year sells you. I want to take a few classes, read books to learn things - parts of history that didn’t stick through school, or Spanish so I can help my kids with homework without so much google translation. We need a vacation that feels different, exciting. I learned from our covid quarantine week that we need more time just playing and hanging, as opposed to schedules and sports and social plans that I naturally tend towards. That includes me, stopping, not wiping down counters when I can afford to sit and compose some legos, or bead for a bit instead. I can feel and see a different season with my kids and while I definitely prefer it to toddlerhood (preach!), it feels like things are moving quickly and I’ll have to stay connected

to myself, to see these simple, magical moments with my family.

With that said, let me share this casserole that went over really well with my Sprouted Kitchen Cooking Club folks. It’s two pans and veggies that can be swapped and kid friendly because who doesn’t love orzo? I delivered one to a friend who said it stretched for two meals, so keep this in your back pocket for delivery.

It’s like a mac n cheese-ish pasta bake but with some vegetables in it. My kids like broccoli, but you could get away with whatever your people like in similar volume, and cooked before adding it in. So long as the mushrooms are super small, I can squeeze those by them. Sub in peas or hunks of cooked butternut squash or add in 1/2 lb. of browned Italian sausage if you prefer an animal protein in there.

If you’re making this to deliver or freeze, assemble everything through the panko parm topper, and wrap it in foil. Pass along directions to bring it to room temperature before baking.

2 Tbsp. of extra virgin olive oil or butter 1 small yellow onion - chopped small 8 oz. of mushrooms - wiped clean, super well chopped 3 cloves of garlic - minced sea salt pepper 2/3 cup of white wine 1 pinch of red pepper flakes 2 tsp. of fresh thyme leaves 3 cups of vegetable or chicken stock 1/2 lb. of orzo (about 1 heaping cup) 10 oz. of broccoli florets - steamed & chopped 1/2 cup of heavy cream 1 lemon - zested 4 oz. of grated fontina or Italian cheese blend

class="">In a large Dutch oven or skillet over medium, heat your oil or butter. Add the onion, and sauté a few minutes until tender. Add the mushrooms, garlic, big pinches of salt and pepper and sauté another 5 minutes, until the liquid is released and you get some browning. Stir in the wine and cook another 5 minutes to cook down. Stir in the pepper flakes, thyme, and turn off the heat.

class="">Transfer the orzo and any residual broth to the pot with the mushrooms. Add the steamed broccoli, cream, lemon zest, cheese and another pinch of salt and pepper. Fold everything to combine. It should be loose.

class="">Transfer the mixture to your prepared pan. Sprinkle the panko and parm on top, and drizzle it with olive oil (it can be refrigerated for a day or frozen at this point. Bring the refrigerated one to room temperature before baking. Cook the frozen one, covered for 25 then uncovered for 20). Bake for 20 minutes, uncovered, until the top is golden brown.

class="">Jovial makes a cassava-based orzo. It can get gummy, but I think it will still work here. It's possible a long-grain brown rice would work here, too. I would just steam it before assembling, and add two eggs in there if you can to help it hold some shape.

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FRONT PAGE

A celebration of wildness and wonder: the Peak District national park at 75

Roly Smith · *The Guardian Travel*

The wild moors and gentle dales of the UK's oldest national park are just as inviting today as they were when it was created in 1951

Look at a satellite photograph of Britain taken on a clear night and the only things visible are the glowing street lights of towns and cities. If you cast your eyes to the centre of northern England, the distinctive, cupped-hand-shaped boundary of the Peak District national park is clearly outlined as an island of darkness washed by an ocean of light from the industrial conurbations of the north and Midlands.

It was established in April 1951 as the first national park in Britain. And that view from space gives the clearest indication possible of why this site was chosen – it put a national park where it was most needed in the country. It has been estimated that about a third of the population of England and Wales lives less than an hour away from the Peak District .

Continue reading...

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FEATURES

We Tried Them All: The Best Meal Kit Delivery Services

Taste of Home Editorial Team · Taste of Home

Best Overall: Martha Stewart & Marley Spoon

Why We Love It: Marley Spoon stood out for its restaurant-quality flavors, straightforward recipes and hearty portions. Our only criticism was how some ingredients are packaged. Read our Marley Spoon review .

Current Offers: Get 45% your first box with free shipping, then save on your next four orders.

Best for Families: HelloFresh

Why We Love It: HelloFresh impressed us with its flavorful, thoughtfully designed meals. We also loved the easy ordering process and flexible add-ons, though prep times occasionally ran longer than expected. Read our HelloFresh review .

Current Offers: Get 10 free meals and a free NutriBullet Ultra Plus on your third box with code TMB10NUTRIB .

Best Budget: EveryPlate

Why We Love It: Our testers found EveryPlate delivers robust, satisfying meals for as little as \$4.99 per serving. Expect fewer recipe filters and the need to supply some basic pantry ingredients, though. Read our EveryPlate review .

Current Offers: Pay just \$2.99 per meal on your first box, plus score 10% off one month with code TMB299MFB.

Best for Beginners: Gobble

Why We Love It: Gobble stood out for its pre-prepped ingredients and ultra-fast cooking times, making it especially approachable for beginners. However, it wasn't the most flavorful meal kit we tried. Read our Gobble review .

Current Offers: Take \$100 off your first four boxes and score free shipping.

Best Gluten-Friendly: Green Chef

Why We Love It: We praised Green Chef's organic ingredients and complex flavor combinations, though the total prep and cook time occasionally exceeded the recipe estimate. Read our Green Chef review .

Current Offers: Get 50% off your first box, then take 20% off for two months.

Best for Gourmets: Blue Apron

Why We Love It: Blue Apron impressed testers with gourmet, restaurant-style dishes and rich flavors. Like many other kits we tested, the recipes often required more time and effort to prepare than advertised. Read our Blue Apron review .

Current Offers: Take \$25 off your first two orders with code WELCOME25 .

Best Semi-Prepared: Sunbasket

Why We Love It: Sunbasket's semi-prepared kits make cooking fast and convenient. The creative recipes are also a bonus. Just know that the premade meals don't always match the quality of the kits. Read our Sunbasket review .

Current Offers: Take \$90 off your first four boxes, plus score free shipping.

Best Plant-Based: Purple Carrot

Why We Love It: Even meat eaters were impressed by Purple Carrot's creative plant-based dishes and strong flavors. Pricing transparency and delivery flexibility were the only noted issues. Read our Purple Carrot review .

Current Offers: Get \$100 off your first month.

Why We Love It: Tempo impressed testers with satisfying microwave-ready meals that require zero prep. The weekly menu is relatively small, which could hinder creative cooks. Read our Tempo review .

Current Offers: Get 60% off your first box.

Best Keto-Friendly: Home Chef

Why We Love It: Home Chef earned high marks for its flavorful meals, easy instructions and strong keto-friendly selection. However, our testers noticed occasional pricing discrepancies. Read our Home Chef review .

Current Offers: Enjoy meals for \$4.99 a serving and get free dessert for life.

Editor's Note: Most offers are available only to new subscribers, while supplies last. Check each merchant's terms and conditions for full details.

What to Look for When Subscribing to a Meal Kit Delivery Service

With more meal delivery service options than ever, how do you choose the right one? Reviews (like ours!) can help, but it's also important to consider factors like cost, flexibility, dietary needs, ingredient quality, and how much cooking effort you're actually up for.

Below, we break down the key things to look for—with helpful insights from two experts: Debbie Petripain, MBA, RDN, Spokesperson for the Academy of Nutrition and Dietetics and Rachel Kirk, food blogger at LaughingSpatula .

Dietary needs and nutrition balance: If you or a family member has specific dietary needs like gluten-free, dairy-free, vegetarian, vegan, keto or low-sodium, choose a service that clearly labels its meals and offers variety within those categories. “Always review the ingredients for

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How Learning Spanish Opens a Window onto the Spanish Civil War

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

There is a particular kind of thrill that comes from reading a historical document in its original language. The words land differently — heavier, more alive, stripped of the buffer that translation provides. For anyone drawn to the Spanish Civil War (1936–1939), one of the twentieth century’s most passionate and heartbreaking conflicts, learning Spanish is not merely a practical skill. It is an act of historical immersion. The slogans, the poetry, the propaganda, the letters home from the front — none of them survive translation entirely intact.

The war itself was fought in language as much as in trenches. Republicans rallied around ¡No pasarán! — “They shall not pass!” Nationalists answered with ¡España, una, grande, libre! Both sides understood that words could mobilize, terrify, and outlast bullets. To understand the war, you need to understand the language in which it was waged.

Republican Spain drew on a rich vocabulary of labor and revolution, much of it borrowed from anarchist and socialist traditions. Terms like *compañero* (comrade), *militia* (militia), and *frente popular* (popular front) were not just descriptors — they were identity markers that signaled allegiance and ideology. George Orwell, who fought with the POUM militia in Catalonia, wrote extensively about how the language of the Republic shaped daily life in *Homage to Catalonia*. Even the act of addressing strangers with the informal *tú* rather than the formal *usted* was, for a time, a political statement.

Dr. Helen Graham, one of Britain’s leading historians of modern Spain and author of *The Spanish Republic at War*, has argued that understanding Republican Spain requires grappling with the fragmented and contested nature of the movement itself. “The Republic was not a single thing,” she has noted, “but a coalition of sometimes opposing visions — and that fracturing was visible in the language different factions used to describe the same events.” Reading Republican pamphlets and manifestos in Spanish reveals these fault lines with a precision that no secondary source can fully replicate.

The Nationalist side deployed a different lexicon, one rooted in Catholic nationalism, military honor, and the language of “crusade.” Franco’s regime famously described the coup as a *cruzada* — a term loaded with centuries of Reconquista mythology. The word *patria* (homeland) and *orden* (order) appeared incessantly in Nationalist broadcasts and newspapers, framing the uprising as a defense of timeless Spanish values against a foreign “red” menace.

Paul Preston, the preeminent English-language historian of the Franco era and the author of the exhaustive biography *Franco: A Biography*, has spent decades analyzing how the regime constructed and weaponized language. Preston emphasizes that Francoist rhetoric was deliberately designed to make the war’s violence seem both necessary

and righteous — and that this rhetorical architecture is most visible when read in the original Spanish, where the cadence and connotation of the vocabulary carry a weight that translations inevitably flatten.

The effects of this linguistic policy stretched well beyond the war itself. As scholars have documented, Franco’s censorship regime — which required every book published in Spain between 1936 and 1966 to pass through a national board of censors — distorted the country’s cultural memory for generations. Understanding that distortion requires reading both what was published and what was suppressed, and for that, you need the language.

No discussion of the Spanish Civil War’s relationship to language would be complete without acknowledging the extraordinary literary culture it produced. Federico García Lorca, murdered by Nationalist forces in the opening weeks of the conflict, had already established Spanish poetry as a living, politically charged art form. Miguel Hernández, the shepherd-poet from Orihuela who fought for the Republic and died in Franco’s prisons, wrote verses whose power rests entirely on the music of Castilian Spanish.

The Republican anthem *Ay Carmela*, sung by soldiers at the front, draws on folk traditions that make immediate sense to a Spanish speaker but that require lengthy annotation for anyone relying on a translation. The same is true of the labor anthem *A las barricadas* and of the countless *corridos* and *coplas* that circulated through both camps. These texts are primary sources. They record what people believed, feared, and hoped for. Learning Spanish means being able to encounter them on their own terms.

Castellano — standard Spanish — is only part of the picture. The Civil War also played out through Catalan, Basque, and Galician, languages whose suppression under Francoism became a form of cultural erasure. Barcelona, the anarchist heartland, was a Catalan-speaking city. The Basque Country, despite being predominantly Catholic, largely sided with the Republic in defense of its regional autonomy — a political irony that makes little sense without understanding the linguistic and cultural stakes involved.

Dr. Mary Vincent, a historian at the University of Sheffield whose work focuses on religion, gender, and the Spanish Civil War, has written about how Francoist language policy — the brutal suppression of regional languages in favor of a monolithic Castilian identity — was itself a form of violence. The history of this suppression is still being written. Spain’s ongoing excavation of mass graves and the parallel effort to recover silenced languages and cultures are, in many ways, the same project. To read Spanish is to begin understanding this landscape; to learn something of Catalan or Basque alongside it is to understand why the war’s wounds have never fully healed.

The Spanish Civil War is one of the most extensively documented conflicts in modern European history. The archives in Salamanca, Seville, and Barcelona hold

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History Through the Lens of Children's Literature: What Fairy Tales Reveal About the Past

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

Fairy tales enchant with their fantastical elements, yet they also expose harsh realities of the past. You might wonder how these seemingly simple stories encapsulate complex societal norms and historical contexts. As you explore the origins and evolution of these narratives, you'll uncover the cultural reflections they offer, revealing much about gender roles, moral lessons, and the fears that shaped societies. What hidden truths lie within these tales that continue to resonate today?

Fairy tales have captivated audiences for centuries, with their origins tracing back to oral traditions that predate written language. You can see how these stories evolved as they were passed down through generations, often adapting to the cultural contexts of their tellers. The earliest forms of fairy tales likely emerged as a way to convey moral lessons, entertain, and explain the inexplicable.

As you explore their history, you'll notice that many tales blend the fantastic with the everyday, reflecting the realities of the societies that spawned them. Characters like cunning tricksters or valiant heroes illustrate the values and fears of their time.

While the Brothers Grimm and Charles Perrault are often credited with popularizing fairy tales, countless variations existed long before their collections. These tales serve as a mirror, revealing the hopes, dreams, and struggles of the people who told them. These narratives are also useful educational tools today, especially in an online school K-12 setting, where fairy tales help students explore history, ethics, and cultural change through engaging, age-appropriate storytelling.

How do stories reflect the cultures from which they emerge? When you plunge into fairy tales, you uncover a tapestry of beliefs, values, and social norms that define a society. These narratives often encapsulate the daily lives of their characters, showcasing the customs, traditions, and struggles of the people.

As you explore various fairy tales, you might notice recurring motifs, such as the hero's journey or the triumph of good over evil. These themes aren't just entertaining—they mirror the hopes and fears of the culture that birthed them.

Additionally, fairy tales can highlight regional differences, showcasing local legends and folklore that enrich cultural heritage. By examining these narratives, you gain insight not only into the values of the time but also into the evolution of those values as societies change.

Stories not only reflect cultural identities but also impart morals and lessons that resonate across generations. Fairy tales, in particular, serve as vehicles for these timeless teachings, adapting their messages to fit the evolving social landscape. As you explore these narratives, you'll

notice how lessons about virtues like honesty, bravery, and kindness remain relevant, even as the specifics of each tale shift.

Take, for instance, the classic tale of Cinderella. Originally, it emphasized the importance of virtue and patience, highlighting the rewards of good behavior. Over time, adaptations have shifted focus, incorporating themes of empowerment and self-advocacy, which mirror contemporary values. This evolution showcases a society's changing priorities.

Similarly, stories like Little Red Riding Hood caution against naivety, reflecting historical concerns about trust and safety. As you analyze these tales, you'll see how the underlying morals adapt to address the fears and aspirations of their time, providing a rich tapestry of lessons that inform both children and adults.

Ultimately, these narratives endure not just for their entertainment value, but for their ability to convey essential life lessons, ensuring that each generation learns from the past while looking toward the future.

Understanding the historical context of popular tales enriches our appreciation of their narratives and themes. When you investigate these stories, you notice they often mirror the societal values and challenges of their time. For example, tales like "Cinderella" and "Little Red Riding Hood" emerged during periods of significant social change, reflecting anxieties about class mobility and the dangers lurking in the world.

As you explore the origins of these tales, consider how they were shaped by the cultural norms and expectations of their respective eras. The oral tradition of storytelling often meant that these narratives evolved with each retelling, adapting to the audience's needs and the prevailing attitudes.

By analyzing the historical context, you can identify the underlying messages about resilience, morality, and social hierarchy. The way these stories address conflicts—like poverty, betrayal, or love—reveals much about the human experience and societal structures.

Ultimately, understanding the historical backdrop allows you to grasp why these tales have endured through generations, resonating with audiences across cultures and time periods. You'll find that fairy tales offer more than just entertainment; they serve as a compelling lens through which to view history itself.

When you plunge into children's literature, it's crucial to ignore the influence of gender roles and stereotypes woven throughout these narratives. These tales not only entertain but also shape societal perceptions of what it means to be male or female.

Children's literature often embeds fear and cautionary elements that serve as powerful tools for moral and

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MUSHROOM, LEEK + GRUYERE STRATA

Sara Forte · Sprouted Kitchen

While more rich than our everyday fare, this year needs a Christmas breakfast to top all Christmas breakfasts. We will be making the cinnamon rolls from our Sprouted Kitchen Holidays ebook (gifting half because what better door drop is there). We have made cinnamon rolls the tradition, but everyone is ready for something more substantial after presents. So we're trying this this year - a bread pudding meets frittata and can be tinkered with all sorts of ways to taste.

I've now made a mediterranean version with artichokes and sun-dried tomatoes and feta, or a roasted squash and kale take that I made in smaller little ramekins so it felt like a special dinner. If you're feeding kids? Try getting the vegetables smaller, so they are harder to pick out and the texture sort of blends in.

Emmi Gruyere is a great option here because it has a nutty, assertive flavor and also a melty quality to it. Goes so well with mushrooms and the bread makes this a one-dish wonder. We've been adding the cheese to the kids grilled cheese sandwiches and into mashed potatoes. Check the store locator for where to find it near you.

Mushroom, Leek and Gruyere Strata

This can take so many different combinations! I left it vegetarian, but some browned breakfast sausage or crispy bacon can be stirred in as well with no other changes should you like.

Everything can be assembled the night before and left covered in the fridge overnight. Pull it out first thing in the morning while the oven is preheating and you can enjoy your family instead of working in the kitchen Christmas morning.

1 Tbsp. extra virgin olive oil 1 Tbsp. butter 8 oz. mixed mushrooms, stemmed and sliced 2 small/1 large leek, white and light green parts, cleaned and sliced 4 oz. baby spinach

8 eggs 1 ½ cup whole milk ½ cup cream ½ tsp. sea salt 1/2 tsp. Fresh ground pepper ½ tsp. Dried oregano 1 Tbsp. hot sauce 1 heaping cup/6 oz. grated Emmi Gruyere, shredded

Heat the oil and butter in a large, oven-proof skillet or cast iron pan (about 12"). Add the mushrooms and leeks, a big pinch of salt and pepper and sauté to soften. About 8 minutes. Stir in the baby spinach, turn off the heat, and let it just wilt and cool down. Stir in the toasted bread.

While the vegetables cool down, whisk up your egg mixture. In a large mixing bowl, combine the eggs, milk, cream, salt, pepper, dried oregano, hot sauce and whisk really well to combine. We want to get some air in there. Stir in the gruyere. Pour the egg mixture over the vegetables,

pressing the bread pieces down a bit so they get the custard on all parts. Leave it to soak at room temperature for an hour, or covered, overnight in the refrigerator.

Turn the oven down to 350'. Bake on the middle rack for 30 minutes, or until you shake the pan and the center is no longer liquid. A little jiggle is ok, it will set as it cools down.

Sara Forte 2020-12-22

Mushroom, Leek & Gruyere Strata

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A bread-pudding-meets-frittata breakfast.

8 oz. fresh bread

1 Tbsp. extra virgin olive oil

1 Tbsp. butter

8 oz. mixed mushrooms

1 leek

4 oz. baby spinach

8 eggs

1 ½ cup whole milk

½ cup cream

½ tsp. sea salt

1/2 tsp. Fresh ground pepper

½ tsp. Dried oregano

1 Tbsp. hot sauce

1 cup shredded Gruyere

423 calories 26 grams fat 27 grams carbohydrate 21 grams protein

Preheat the oven to 375'. Spread the cubed bread on a baking dish and toast for 10 minutes until golden on the edges and dried out.

Heat the oil and butter in a large, oven-proof skillet or cast iron pan (about 12"). Add the mushrooms and leeks, a big pinch of salt and pepper and saute to soften. About 8 minutes. Stir in the baby spinach, turn off the heat, and let it just wilt and cool down. Stir in the toasted bread.

While the vegetables cool down, whisk up your egg mixture. In a large mixing bowl, combine the eggs, milk, cream, salt, pepper, dried oregano, hot sauce and whisk really well to combine. We want to get some air in there. Stir in the gruyere. Pour the egg mixture over the vegetables, pressing

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Russian Colonization in Alaska and The Pacific Northwest

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

Peter the Great, one of the most notable Czars in Russian history and famous for opening Russia's windows to the West, played a pivotal role in extending Russian borders further east into Siberia. Summoning a Danish Naval Officer in the service of Russia by the name of Vitus Bering, Czar Peter, in one of his final acts, ordered Bering to lead an expedition to the eastern extremity of the continent to the Kamchatka Peninsula in 1725. From there, Russia would move over to the American continent.

Back in 1725, it was unclear whether Czar Peter and Bering had prior knowledge that Asia and North America were not in fact connected, but the impetus for the exploration appears to have been a joint explorative/probing mission to determine how far west other European powers, especially Spain, had explored. After sailing into the sea which now bears his name, Bering initially failed to reach the North American mainland. It would be more than a decade before he embarked on a second expedition this time successfully reaching what is now Alaska in July 1741. Despite the impressive intrepidity and endurance made by the officers and men of the expedition the most immediate impact upon return to St. Petersburg was the procurement of rich furs, mainly sea otters. This later launched a gradual wave of highly enterprising traders, entrepreneurs and adventurers backed mostly by private or individual fortunes to tap into the fur rush, much like what the French and British had already been doing on the opposite side of the American continent.

Russian fur traders known as Promyshlenniki began to island hop eastward via Siberia and into the Alaskan mainland and broader Pacific Northwest. A relentless campaign ensued to harvest the highly sought after furs of sea otters, foxes, and various northern seals. Once one island/area was rapaciously depleted of furs the hunters and trappers merely moved on to the next and continued to exploit and slaughter. This had a horrific impact on the local native populace as they watched in horror and confusion as their abundant food and survival sources were destroyed and threatened with extinction.

By the 1780s the chaotic free for all operations of independently operating Promyshlenniki steadily gave way as six competing companies arose much like the Hudson's Bay Company in British North America. Under such companies which were typically named for their founder(s) such as the Sheilikhov-Golikov Company. Competition would increase but took on a more organized fashion as the first permanent Russian settlements soon began to emerge because of coordinated and sustained trapping operations.

Despite some coordination and cooperation with the native populace, mainly Aleuts and Tlingits, relationships began to falter despite the pleadings and alleged interest in Native wellbeing of the distant and all too preoccupied monarch Catherine the Great. The all-too-common

clash of cultures kept increasing in intensity and atrocities with several military encounters ensuing. The Natives never could gain a decisive edge given their lack of gunpowder and firearms and became fewer in number.

In 1808 the Russians relocated their erstwhile capital of Russia America from Kodiak Island to Sitka. There they took advantage of secure and deep harbors as they expanded their shipbuilding operations utilizing the abundance of timber in the surrounding area. Consolidating their regional monopoly the Russians virtually controlled much of the Pacific fur trade from the Aleutians to Northern California, providing lucrative furs and pelts to the markets in Asia and North America, even trading consistently with the newly created United States. Russian ships likewise began to sail further south into the Pacific laying anchor at places such as Easter Island and the Hawaiian Archipelago, all at the behest of the Czar who was determined that Russia remain a major player on the global geopolitical stage.

Russia would hold onto its outposts in Alaska ever so tenuously well into the mid-19th century as it faced consistently mounting pressure from the British and American who similarly coveted Alaska and the Pacific Northwest's strategic and economic potential. The Russian attention eastward would wane however with the emphasis on southern extension into the Caucasus's and Central Asia would pit Russia and Great Britain against one another in both hot and cold conflicts such as the Crimean War and the so-called Great Game.

In the 1850s, overhunting and trapping coupled with the bevy of conflicts abroad led to the Russian Empire devoting fewer men, material and resources to its outposts in the Pacific Northwest. Cognizant of Russia's vulnerability from other European powers and prioritization of other regions the Czar decided to entertain and eventually approve a sale of Alaska to the United States in 1867 for the price of seven million dollars, roughly two cents per acre. Thus, ending the near century and a half legacy of Russian activity in North America. To this day the Orthodox Church is still a prominent institution in the now State of Alaska. A vestige harkening back to an often-overlooked chapter in American and Russian history.

*The all-too-common clash of cultures kept increasing in intensity and atrocities
with several military encounters ensuing.*

George Levrier-Jones

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CHOCOLATE-HAZELNUT TOFFEE

Sara Forte · Sprouted Kitchen

It has been a busy cookbook season! I spent last night reading through the Ottolenghi Test Kitchen Cookbook and am revisiting everything I have bookmarked in Aran's Cannelle et Vanille Bakes Simple while it is rainy this week and we can work on some baking projects. If you eat gluten free, by need or choice, Aran is your gal. You may know her from her gf sourdough tutorials on instagram.

Aran is one of my favorite food people. Most importantly, she is a lovely and generous person. Just as humble and charming as her photos lead you to believe. Her photos are romantic, the recipes are clear and uncomplicated and she offers subs for all sorts of dietary issues. She is the gluten free baking master, and always where I go for reference. The book does call for some specialty flours, but if you cook gluten free and make a few things from her book, they won't go to waste. My favorites have been the Lemon Curd, Lemon Pound Cake, Double Chocolate Crinkle Cookies and this toffee! I love how short the list of ingredients is, you may even have everything to make a batch today.

This makes an excellent gift around the holidays. We kept it in the fridge for when you just need a sweet nibble after a meal. If you are nut free, you can sub in some candied pepitas or some crushed candy canes and cocoa nibs on top.

On a second sheet, spread the hazelnuts and roast for 15-20 minutes, until fragrant and golden brown. When they are cool enough to handle, transfer them to a large kitchen towel and rub together to loosen their skins. Once they're mostly peeled (a bit of skin is ok), transfer them to a food processor and pulse a few times to roughly chop. Set aside.

In a medium saucepan, stir together the butter, both sugar, water and salt. Cook over medium-high heat, undisturbed, until it registers at 300°, about 15 minutes. The mixture will be dark brown and smell caramelized. Remove the pan from the heat and carefully add the vanilla, it will splatter. Stir in the baking soda until it is distributed - do not overmix. You want to preserve some of that gas.

Pour the toffee onto the prepared baking sheet and spread it evenly with a spatula. Sprinkle the top with the chopped chocolate. The heat of the toffee will melt it. Spread it evenly with a spatula. Distribute the chopped hazelnuts across the top and press down so they stick into the chocolate.

Let the toffee cool completely for a few hours, or speed up this process in the fridge. Break the toffee into pieces and store in an airtight container for up to a month.

If you are nut free, you can sub in some candied pepitas or some crushed candy canes and cocoa nibs on top.

Sara Forte

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12 Leftover Rice Recipes

Jess Rice · Budget Bytes

I'm all about using up leftovers and not letting anything go to waste. After all, tossing leftover food is one of the quickest ways to watch your grocery budget disappear! Rice is especially sneaky. Even though it's one of the cheapest ingredients in my kitchen, it's also one of the easiest to overestimate, which means a container of cooked rice ends up shoved to the back of the fridge and forgotten until it's too late. So instead of letting that happen, I started treating leftover rice like a planned ingredient. These 12+ leftover rice recipes are some of our favorite ways to turn extra rice into a real meal, not just something to use up!

Before we get into it, a quick rice-storage note (so you can feel good about using it later). When you're storing cooked rice for later, the main goal is to cool it quickly and get it into the fridge, ideally portioned out in a clean container so it chills faster. Cooling cooked rice as soon as possible and then heating it thoroughly before enjoying it again is the best way to keep it food-safe. Don't leave cooked rice sitting out at room temp, and try to get it cooled and refrigerated within about two hours.

You can also freeze rice for up to 2-3 months and then pull it from the freezer to use in any of the recipes below!

Leftover rice is basically a blank canvas, and it can go way beyond basic reheating. These recipes with leftover rice show off all the best directions it can take, from savory to sweet!

I always use leftover rice for fried rice if I can. My family loves it, and I much prefer the texture compared to freshly cooked rice in dishes like these. Day-old rice is a little firmer, so the grains stay separate instead of turning sticky or gummy once I stir in the sauce and add-ins. It's the easiest way to get that perfect fried rice texture at home.

\$4.5 recipe / \$1.13 serving [Get the Recipe](#)

When I need dinner fast and I've got leftover cooked rice in my fridge, I make this vegetable fried rice. It's garlicky, gingery, and finished with soy sauce and toasted sesame oil, plus eggs and a mix of veggies. The whole thing comes together in less than 30 minutes, and it's great for using up odds and ends!

\$4.74 recipe / \$1.19 serving [Get the Recipe](#)

A batch of this chicken fried rice can stretch leftover rice and a single chicken breast into a budget-friendly dinner that tastes even better than takeout (I promise!). This easy recipe feels especially satisfying for how simple the ingredient list really is.

\$5.63 recipe / \$1.40 serving [Get the Recipe](#)

If you like bold flavors, kimchi fried rice is such a fun way to wake up a container of day-old rice. I love how it uses tangy

kimchi, quick-cooking vegetables, and even shredded broccoli stem for extra texture, so it feels resourceful while still being incredibly flavorful. There's no waste in our budget-conscious kitchen!

Casseroles are another spot where I love using day-old rice. Since it's a little firmer, it holds its texture while it bakes instead of turning mushy, and it soaks up flavor easily while making whatever you're cooking extra hearty. If I know a casserole is on the menu, I'll even cook extra rice the night before just to make prep faster.

Chicken and Rice Casserole

\$7.60 recipe / \$1.27 serving [Get the Recipe](#)

For a cozy baked dinner, chicken and rice casserole turns rice, vegetables, chicken, and cheese into a creamy, hearty meal that feels like classic comfort food. It's the kind of casserole that works especially well for using up cooked chicken, including rotisserie chicken, and leftover rice.

\$5.78 recipe / \$0.96 serving [Get the Recipe](#)

I love how our broccoli cheese casserole transforms cooked rice into something creamy, cheesy, and seriously comforting. Broccoli, cheddar, and a simple homemade sauce bake together in about 50 minutes, giving you a side dish that can easily double as the main event.

\$8.10 recipe / \$1.35 serving [Get the Recipe](#)

This beef burrito casserole is layered with seasoned beef, cooked rice, beans, salsa, and cheese, and the little dollops of cream cheese tucked through the middle make it extra creamy and rich. Want to go meatless? I'd skip the ground beef and add in an extra can of black beans or some corn. It'll still be delicious either way!

Bowl meals are my favorite way to make leftover rice feel fresh again. Just add a protein, a few colorful toppings, and a punchy sauce, and suddenly dinner is handled!

Bibimbap – The Ultimate Bowl Meal

\$10.66 recipe / \$2.67 serving [Get the Recipe](#)

Bibimbap is a Korean mixed rice bowl, and our budget-friendly adaptation turns leftover rice into a seriously satisfying dinner. This version keeps things simple with jasmine rice, spinach, chili garlic beef, fresh vegetables, kimchi, and a fried egg, so you still get plenty of color, texture, and flavor without complicated steps. It's also great for meal prep! I'd just cook the egg fresh each day, or swap in a hard-boiled egg instead.

Poor Man's Burrito Bowls

\$7.07 recipe / \$1.18 serving [Get the Recipe](#)

I'm always impressed by how much flavor our poor man's burrito bowls deliver with such a short and affordable

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Fresh Energy In March (2026 Wallpapers Edition)

Cosima Mielke · Smashing Magazine

Blooming flowers, longer days, milder temperatures — with March just around the corner, the world is slowly but surely awakening from its winter slumber, fueling us with fresh energy. And even if spring is far away in your part of the world, you might sense that 2026 has gained full speed by now, making it the perfect moment to turn those plans and ideas you've been carrying around into action.

To accompany you on all those adventures that March may bring, we have a new collection of desktop wallpapers for you, just as it has been a monthly tradition here at Smashing Magazine for more than 14 years already. Designed by artists and designers from across the globe, each wallpaper comes in a variety of screen resolutions and can be downloaded for free. A huge thank-you to everyone who shared their designs with us — this post wouldn't be possible without your kind support!

If you, too, would like to get featured in one of our upcoming wallpapers editions, please don't hesitate to submit your design. We can't wait to see what you'll come up with! Happy March!

You can click on every image to see a larger preview.

We respect and carefully consider the ideas and motivation behind each and every artist's work. This is why we give all artists the full freedom to explore their creativity and express emotions and experience through their works. This is also why the themes of the wallpapers weren't anyhow influenced by us but rather designed from scratch by the artists themselves.

"With Spring knocking and other seasons fighting to get attention, March greets us with blossoms." — Designed by Ginger It Solutions from Serbia.

preview

with calendar: 320x480, 640x480, 800x480, 800x600, 1024x768, 1024x1024, 1152x864, 1280x720, 1280x800, 1280x960, 1280x1020, 1400x1050, 1440x900, 1600x1200, 1680x1050, 1680x1200, 1920x1080, 1920x1200, 1920x1440, 2560x1440

without calendar: 320x480, 640x480, 800x480, 800x600, 1024x768, 1024x1024, 1152x864, 1280x720, 1280x800, 1280x960, 1280x1020, 1400x1050, 1440x900, 1600x1200, 1680x1050, 1680x1200, 1920x1080, 1920x1200, 1920x1440, 2560x1440

preview

with calendar: 640x480, 800x480, 800x600, 1024x768, 1024x1024, 1152x864, 1280x720, 1280x800, 1280x960, 1280x1024, 1366x768, 1400x1050, 1440x900, 1600x1200, 1680x1050, 1680x1200, 1920x1080, 1920x1200, 1920x1440, 2560x1440, 3840x2160

without calendar: 640x480, 800x480, 800x600, 1024x768, 1024x1024, 1152x864, 1280x720, 1280x800, 1280x960, 1280x1024, 1366x768, 1400x1050, 1440x900, 1600x1200, 1680x1050, 1680x1200, 1920x1080, 1920x1200, 1920x1440, 2560x1440, 3840x2160

I'm Not Okay, But It's Okay

preview

with calendar: 640x480, 800x480, 800x600, 1024x768, 1024x1024, 1152x864, 1280x720, 1280x800, 1280x960, 1280x1024, 1366x768, 1400x1050, 1440x900, 1600x1200, 1680x1050, 1680x1200, 1920x1080, 1920x1200, 1920x1440, 2560x1440, 3840x2160

without calendar: 640x480, 800x480, 800x600, 1024x768, 1024x1024, 1152x864, 1280x720, 1280x800, 1280x960, 1280x1024, 1366x768, 1400x1050, 1440x900, 1600x1200, 1680x1050, 1680x1200, 1920x1080, 1920x1200, 1920x1440, 2560x1440, 3840x2160

Let's Spring

"After some freezing months, it's time to enjoy the sun and flowers. It's party time, colors are coming, so let's spring!" — Designed by Colorsfera from Spain.

preview

without calendar: 320x480, 640x480, 800x480, 800x600, 1024x768, 1024x1024, 1152x864, 1280x720, 1280x800, 1280x960, 1280x1020, 1400x1050, 1440x900, 1600x1200, 1680x1050, 1680x1200, 1920x1080, 1920x1200, 1920x1440, 2560x1440

"This March, our calendar design epitomizes the heralds of spring. Soon enough, you'll be waking up to the singing of swallows, in a room full of sunshine, filled with the empowering smell of daffodil, the first springtime flowers. Spring is the time of rebirth and new beginnings, creativity and inspiration, self-awareness, and inner reflection. Have a budding, thriving spring!" — Designed by PopArt Studio from Serbia.

preview

without calendar: 320x480, 640x480, 800x480, 800x600, 1024x768, 1024x1024, 1152x864, 1280x720, 1280x800, 1280x960, 1280x1024, 1366x768, 1440x900, 1440x1050, 1600x1200, 1680x1050, 1680x1200, 1920x1080, 1920x1200, 1920x1440, 2560x1440

"This month, I want to go to the woods and explore my new world in sunny weather." — Designed by Zi-Cing Hong from Taiwan.

preview

without calendar: 1024x768, 1152x864, 1280x720, 1280x800, 1280x960, 1366x768, 1400x1050, 1440x900, 1600x1200, 1680x1050, 1920x1080, 1920x1200, 1920x1440, 2560x1440

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GLUTEN FREE CRANBERRY TEA CAKE

Sara Forte · Sprouted Kitchen

class="">Fa la la la la! It's baking season and this cake was a hit. Of course we all love cookies, and I have plenty of those on the list. My people love a breakfast sweet, and this has stood in for a simple dinner dessert on occasion as well. I know you all love to have a spread planned for holiday mornings, so hope this works for those of you gluten free folks. We always have sweet rolls, but I may double up this year since everyone liked this cake so much. I'll say it again, like we do with the lemon loaf or banana bread, toasted for a few minutes for a bit of a crisp edge is lovely.

class="">I have made many dense gf baked goods, but I'm starting to figure out the ratios. Eggs are important for strength, going all almond flour turns out pretty dense, so I cut it with superfine brown rice flour like I learned from Aran of Canelle et Vanille. Hugh is the gluten free one in the family, but I have found the kids don't question a thing when it looks like cookies and cake and sugar. I added some swap suggestions in the headnote.

GLUTEN FREE CRANBERRY TEA CAKE

class="">This could be part of a breakfast spread or a dessert. It is sweet and seasonal but we nibbled at it most in the afternoon with a second (er, third) cup of coffee or tea. It has a good amount of moisture, so it sits well at room temperature for a day or two, then should be kept covered in the fridge. Great served with a dollop of plain yogurt in the morning or sweetened creme fraiche for dessert.

class="">Dairy-free option is to replace the buttermilk with non-dairy milk with a squeeze of lemon juice - oat or almond both great, coconut is a bit heavy. You don't need it gluten free, replace the almond and rice flours with 1 1/2 cups all purpose flour.

class="">6 Tbsp. unsalted butter (vegan butter works great!), room temperature 3/4 cup cane sugar 2 Tbsp. avocado or coconut oil 2 eggs 1/2 cup buttermilk (or non-dairy milk with a squeeze of lemon juice) 1/4 cup maple syrup 1 tsp. vanilla extract zest of one orange 1 cup almond flour 1 cup superfine brown rice flour (I buy this one) 2 tsp. baking powder 1/2 tsp. sea salt 2 cups (8 oz.) fresh or frozen cranberries, roughly chopped

class="">In a stand mixer or with an electric mixer, beat the butter and sugar together until fluffy. At least 3 minutes. Add the oil, eggs, buttermilk, maple, vanilla, orange zest and beat again to incorporate. Add the almond and rice flours, baking powder, salt and fold it a few times. Add half the cranberries and fold again. Transfer it to your prepared pan, sprinkle the remaining cranberries over top, swipe it down to an even layer, and sprinkle the top generously with turbinado sugar.

class="">Bake on the middle rack for about 50 minutes, until tested in the center and only a few crumbs (no batter!) come out with it. If the top starts to get to brown, cover it

with a piece of parchment or foil. Let the cake cool for at least 30 minutes before slicing. Serve with yogurt or sweetened creme fraiche.

*unsalted butter (vegan butter works great!), room temperature 3/4 cup cane
sugar 2 Tbsp.*

Sara Forte

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Beyond The Black Box: Practical XAI For UX Practitioners

Victor Yocco · Smashing Magazine

In my last piece , we established a foundational truth: for users to adopt and rely on AI, they must trust it. We talked about trust being a multifaceted construct, built on perceptions of an AI's Ability , Benevolence , Integrity , and Predictability . But what happens when an AI, in its silent, algorithmic wisdom, makes a decision that leaves a user confused, frustrated, or even hurt? A mortgage application is denied, a favorite song is suddenly absent from a playlist, and a qualified resume is rejected before a human ever sees it. In these moments, ability and predictability are shattered, and benevolence feels a world away.

Our conversation now must evolve from the why of trust to the how of transparency. The field of Explainable AI (XAI) , which focuses on developing methods to make AI outputs understandable to humans, has emerged to address this, but it's often framed as a purely technical challenge for data scientists. I argue it's a critical design challenge for products relying on AI. It's our job as UX professionals to bridge the gap between algorithmic decision-making and human understanding.

This article provides practical, actionable guidance on how to research and design for explainability. We'll move beyond the buzzwords and into the mockups, translating complex XAI concepts into concrete design patterns you can start using today.

De-mystifying XAI: Core Concepts For UX Practitioners

XAI is about answering the user's question: " Why? " Why was I shown this ad? Why is this movie recommended to me? Why was my request denied? Think of it as the AI showing its work on a math problem. Without it, you just have an answer, and you're forced to take it on faith. In showing the steps, you build comprehension and trust. You also allow for your work to be double-checked and verified by the very humans it impacts.

There are a number of techniques we can use to clarify or explain what is happening with AI. While methods range from providing the entire logic of a decision tree to generating natural language summaries of an output, two of the most practical and impactful types of information UX practitioners can introduce into an experience are feature importance (Figure 1) and counterfactuals . These are often the most straightforward for users to understand and the most actionable for designers to implement.

This explainability method answers, " What were the most important factors the AI considered? " It's about identifying the top 2-3 variables that had the biggest impact on the outcome. It's the headline, not the whole story.

Example : Imagine an AI that predicts whether a customer will churn (cancel their service). Feature importance might reveal that "number of support calls in the last month"

and "recent price increases" were the two most important factors in determining if a customer was likely to churn.

This powerful method answers, " What would I need to change to get a different outcome? " This is crucial because it gives users a sense of agency. It transforms a frustrating "no" into an actionable "not yet."

Example : Imagine a loan application system that uses AI. A user is denied a loan. Instead of just seeing "Application Denied," a counterfactual explanation would also share, "If your credit score were 50 points higher, or if your debt-to-income ratio were 10% lower, your loan would have been approved." This gives Sarah clear, actionable steps she can take to potentially get a loan in the future.

Using Model Data To Enhance The Explanation

Although technical specifics are often handled by data scientists, it's helpful for UX practitioners to know that tools like LIME (Local Interpretable Model-agnostic Explanations) which explains individual predictions by approximating the model locally, and SHAP (SHapley Additive exPlanations) which uses a game theory approach to explain the output of any machine learning model are commonly used to extract these "why" insights from complex models. These libraries essentially help break down an AI's decision to show which inputs were most influential for a given outcome.

When done properly, the data underlying an AI tool's decision can be used to tell a powerful story. Let's walk through feature importance and counterfactuals and show how the data science behind the decision can be utilized to enhance the user's experience.

Now let's cover feature importance with the assistance of Local Explanations (e.g., LIME) data: This approach answers, " Why did the AI make this specific recommendation for me, right now? " Instead of a general explanation of how the model works, it provides a focused reason for a single, specific instance. It's personal and contextual.

Example : Imagine an AI-powered music recommendation system like Spotify. A local explanation would answer, "Why did the system recommend this specific song by Adele to you right now?" The explanation might be: "Because you recently listened to several other emotional ballads and songs by female vocalists."

Finally, let's cover the inclusion of Value-based Explanations (e.g. Shapley Additive Explanations (SHAP) data to an explanation of a decision: This is a more nuanced version of feature importance that answers, " How did each factor push the decision one way or the other? " It helps visualize what mattered, and whether its influence was positive or negative.

Example : Imagine a bank uses an AI model to decide whether to approve a loan application.

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Smashing Animations Part 7: Recreating Toon Text With CSS And SVG

Andy Clarke · Smashing Magazine

After finishing a project that required me to learn everything I could about CSS and SVG animations, I started writing this series about Smashing Animations and “How Classic Cartoons Inspire Modern CSS.” To round off this year, I want to show you how to use modern CSS to create that element that makes Toon Titles so impactful: their typography.

In the silent era of the 1920s and early '30s, the typography of a film's title card created a mood, set the scene, and reminded an audience of the type of film they'd paid to see.

Cartoon title cards were also branding, mood, and scene-setting, all rolled into one. In the early years, when major studio budgets were bigger, these title cards were often illustrative and painterly.

But when television boomed during the 1950s, budgets dropped, and cards designed by artists like Lawrence “Art” Goble adopted a new visual language, becoming more graphic, stylised, and less intricate.

Note: Lawrence “Art” Goble is one of the often overlooked heroes of mid-century American animation. He primarily worked for Hanna-Barbera during its most influential years of the 1950s and 1960s.

Goble wasn't a character animator. His role was to create atmosphere, so he designed environments for The Flintstones, Huckleberry Hound, Quick Draw McGraw, and Yogi Bear, as well as the opening title cards that set the tone. His title cards, featuring paintings with a logo overlaid, helped define the iconic look of Hanna-Barbera.

Goble's artwork for characters such as Quick Draw McGraw and Yogi Bear was effective on smaller TV screens. Rather than reproducing a still from the cartoon, he focused on presenting a single, strong idea — often in silhouette — that captured its essence. In “The Buzzin' Bear,” Yogi buzzes by in a helicopter. He bounces away, pic-a-nic basket in hand, in “Bear on a Picnic,” and for his “Prize Fight Fright,” Yogi boxes the title text.

With little or no motion to rely on, Goble's single frames had to create a mood, set the scene, and describe a story. They did this using flat colours, graphic shapes, and typography that was frequently integrated into the artwork.

As designers who work on the web, toon titles can teach us plenty about how to convey a brand's personality, make a first impression, and set expectations for someone's experience using a product or website. We can learn from the artists' techniques to create effective banners, landing-page headers, and even good ol' fashioned splash screens.

Cartoon title cards show how merging type with imagery delivers the punch a header or hero needs. With a handful

of text-shadow, text-stroke, and transform tricks, modern CSS lets you tap into that same energy.

The Toon Text Title Generator

Partway through writing this article, I realised it would be useful to have a tool for generating text styled like the cartoon titles I love so much. So I made one.

My Toon Text Title Generator lets you experiment with colours, strokes, and multiple text shadows. You can adjust paint order, apply letter spacing, preview your text in a selection of sample fonts, and then copy the generated CSS straight to your clipboard to use in a project.

Toon Title CSS

You can simply copy-paste the CSS that the Toon Text Title Generator provides you. But let's look closer at what it does.

Text shadow

Look at the type in this title from Augie Doggie's episode “Yuk-Yuk Duck,” with its pale yellow letters and dark, hard, offset shadow that lifts it off the background and creates the illusion of depth.

You probably already know that text-shadow accepts four values: (1) horizontal and (2) vertical offsets, (3) blur, and (4) a colour which can be solid or semi-transparent. Those offset values can be positive or negative, so I can replicate “Yuk-Yuk Duck” using a hard shadow pulled down and to the right:

```
color: #f7f76d; text-shadow: 5px 5px 0 #1e1904;
```

On the other hand, this “Pint Giant” title has a different feel with its negative semi-soft shadow:

```
color: #c2a872; text-shadow: -7px 5px 0 #b100e, 0 -5px 10px #546c6f;
```

To add extra depth and create more interesting effects, I can layer multiple shadows. For “Let's Duck Out,” I combine four shadows: the first a solid shadow with a negative horizontal offset to lift the text off the background, followed by progressively softer shadows to create a blur around it:

```
color: #6f4d80; text-shadow: -5px 5px 0 #260e1e, /* Shadow 1 */ 0 0 15px #e9ce96, /* Shadow 2 */ 0 0 30px #e9ce96, /* Shadow 3 */ 0 0 30px #e9ce96; /* Shadow 4 */
```

These shadows show that using text-shadow isn't just about creating lighting effects, as they can also be decorative and add personality.

Many cartoon title cards feature letters with a bold outline that makes them stand out from the background. I can recreate this effect using text-stroke. For a long time, this property was only available via a -webkit- prefix, but that also means it's now supported across modern browsers.

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World War 2's Burma Campaign & Gurkha Lachhiman Gurung VC

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

Lachhiman Gurung's story cannot be fully understood without appreciating the wider context of the Burma Campaign, one of the most demanding and least forgiving theatres of the Second World War. Fought across dense jungle, steep mountains, monsoon-soaked valleys, and primitive supply routes, the campaign pitted Allied forces against a Japanese army that had already demonstrated its ability to defeat larger, better-equipped opponents through mobility, surprise, and ferocious determination. Within this brutal environment, Gurung's stand in May 1945 represents not just individual heroism, but the culmination of years of attritional warfare in which endurance was often as decisive as firepower.

Born in 1917 in the village of Chhimba in Nepal's Gorkha district, Lachhiman Gurung grew up in a society where military service was both an economic opportunity and a source of deep cultural pride. Gurkha soldiers had been recruited into the British Indian Army since the early nineteenth century, valued for their toughness, adaptability, and fierce regimental loyalty. Gurung enlisted in the 8th Gurkha Rifles, a regiment that had already seen extensive action in both world wars. By the time Japan entered the conflict in Southeast Asia in 1941, Gurkha units were among the most experienced light infantry forces available to the British Empire, well-suited to jungle warfare and long-range patrolling.

The Japanese invasion of Burma in 1942 had driven British and Indian forces into a humiliating retreat to India, but by 1944 the strategic balance had begun to shift. The failure of the Japanese offensives at Imphal and Kohima marked a turning point, after which Allied forces, reorganized and resupplied, began a relentless advance back into Burma. By 1945, the Japanese 15th Army and associated formations were exhausted, understrength, and increasingly isolated, yet they remained dangerous opponents. Japanese doctrine emphasized aggressive night attacks, infiltration, and the willingness of small units to fight to the death rather than withdraw. Defensive positions were often assaulted repeatedly at close quarters, with grenades, bayonets, and hand-to-hand combat playing a decisive role.

It was against this backdrop that Rifleman Lachhiman Gurung found himself holding a forward position near Taungdaw on the night of 12–13 May 1945. His battalion was engaged in clearing remaining pockets of Japanese resistance as Allied forces pushed southwards. Forward positions such as Gurung's were particularly vulnerable, often lightly manned and deliberately exposed to give early warning of enemy movement. Japanese troops, skilled at moving silently through jungle and darkness, frequently attempted to overwhelm such posts with sudden grenade attacks followed by a close assault.

During the night, a determined Japanese attack fell upon Gurung's trench, which he shared with two

fellow Gurkhas. Grenades were hurled into the position in rapid succession. When one grenade landed directly among them, Gurung attempted to throw it clear, a reflexive act that likely saved the wider position even as it cost him dearly. The explosion tore off two of his fingers, shattered his right arm, and inflicted multiple wounds to his face and body. His two comrades were killed instantly. In most circumstances, such injuries would have rendered a soldier helpless, if not unconscious, but Gurung remained upright and aware, driven by a sense of duty that overrode shock and pain.

Alone in the trench and severely wounded, Gurung faced repeated Japanese assaults at extremely close range. The attacking soldiers were likely drawn from veteran infantry units accustomed to night fighting, armed with grenades, rifles, and bayonets, and prepared to press home attacks regardless of casualties. Gurung, unable to properly use his damaged arm, adapted with grim ingenuity. Using his remaining hand and his teeth, he picked up grenades and hurled them back at the attackers, while firing his weapon whenever possible. For several hours, he held his position, repelling one attack after another, despite loss of blood, exhaustion, and the knowledge that no immediate help could reach him.

By dawn, the Japanese attacks had ceased. The ground in front of Gurung's trench was strewn with enemy dead, grim evidence of the effectiveness of his solitary defense. More importantly, the position had not fallen. In the tightly interlinked defensive system of jungle warfare, the loss of a forward post could allow enemy forces to infiltrate behind the main line, threatening encirclement or collapse. Gurung's refusal to yield under such conditions almost certainly prevented further casualties among his unit and contributed directly to the success of the local operation.

The award of the Victoria Cross recognized not only the extraordinary courage displayed but also the broader military significance of Gurung's actions. His citation highlighted his "indomitable spirit" and "complete disregard for his own safety," qualities that epitomized the ideal of the Gurkha soldier. At a time when the Burma Campaign was approaching its conclusion, his story resonated strongly with Allied forces who had endured years of hardship in one of the war's harshest environments.

After surviving his wounds, Lachhiman Gurung was discharged from the army with a disability pension. He returned to Nepal, where, like many Gurkha veterans, he lived a modest life far removed from the battlefields that had defined his youth. Despite being one of the few Nepalese recipients of the Victoria Cross, he remained characteristically humble, rarely speaking about his wartime experiences unless pressed. In later years, he was honored at commemorative events and remembered with deep respect within Gurkha circles and beyond. Lachhiman Gurung died in 2004, leaving behind a legacy that stands as one of the most remarkable individual acts of bravery in the Second World War and a powerful reminder of the human endurance displayed during the long and punishing struggle.

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40 Summer Cake Recipes You Need to Try

Emily Racette Parulski · Taste of Home

From the Recipe Creator: Showcase the bright flavors of spring with this delightfully refreshing lemon blueberry cake. Lemon juice and zest give a citrusy punch, while sprinkled blueberries give a touch of sweetness. —Sarah Farmer, Waukesha, Wisconsin

Pineapple Upside-Down Cake

From the Recipe Creator: A classic recipe like this never goes out of style! It's delicious with the traditional pineapple, but try it with peaches or a combination of cranberries and orange. —Bernardine Melton, Paola, Kansas

From the Recipe Creator: This layered strawberry Bundt cake is a real celebration of strawberries. It has a cheery pink hue and a bright strawberry flavor. —Nancy Mock, Southbridge, Massachusetts

From the Recipe Creator: My mother used to love making this easy pineapple sunshine cake in the summertime. It's so cool and refreshing that it never lasts very long! —Kathleen Worden, North Andover, Massachusetts

A pound cake offers a buttery, tender crumb with a soft, golden crust. To make the classic version even better, we added fresh fruit into the mix. This cake starts with a vanilla cake base and is flecked with berries. With its pretty pink glaze, it's special enough for any party or occasion, or you could simply enjoy a slice with afternoon tea. —Molly Allen, Hood River, Oregon

From the Recipe Creator: When my boys were young, they couldn't drink milk but they could have yogurt. This was a cake they could eat. And it's one dessert that doesn't taste overly sweet, which is always a nice change of pace. —Linda Leuer, Hamel, Minnesota

Pineapple RumChata Shortcakes

This deliciously different dessert, with a soft inside and a crumbly crust, is made in the slow cooker in jars instead of in the oven. When done, add final touches to the cooled shortcake jars and serve. —Joan Hallford, North Richland Hills, Texas

From the Recipe Creator: As a mother of three sons, I always have sweets in my kitchen! I buy lots of ripe bananas on sale and freeze them with this cake in mind. I'm often asked to bring it to family picnics and dinners. —Bonnie Krause, Irvona, Pennsylvania

From the Recipe Creator: This bright and moist lemon cake is topped with a mascarpone frosting. Garnish it with lemon zest for an extra pop of color. —Taste of Home Test Kitchen

From the Recipe Creator: This tender cake roll with whipped cream has a very light texture and is perfect for spring. The raspberries give the whipped cream filling a pretty pale pink color. Strawberries could also be used instead of raspberries. —Kaori Shinohara, Paramus, New Jersey

This vanilla and cinnamon cake is mixed in with juicy peaches, so every bite is tender and sweet. Serve warm with vanilla ice cream. —Taste of Home Test Kitchen

From the Recipe Creator: Toasted coconut adds visual appeal to this tall and impressive cake. With an airy texture and heavenly coconut-ginger flavor, it's a lovely end to meals throughout the year.

From the Recipe Creator: Ube cake highlights the sweet, yet earthy flavors of the purple yam with ube extract and ube jam. Coconut macapuno tops the two-tiered cake for a striking, traditional finish to the Filipino dessert. —Margaret Knoebel, Milwaukee, Wisconsin

Strawberry Pretzel Salad Poke Cake

I once had a friend who was obsessed with strawberry pretzel dip. For her birthday one summer, I created this strawberry pretzel salad poke cake to celebrate. I've been making it every year for her since. —Lauren Habermehl, Pewaukee, Wisconsin

From the Recipe Creator: Lemon pie filling lends a splash of citrus flavor to a convenient cake mix, and a rich cream cheese frosting gives the cake sweetness. My family likes this dessert cold, so I cut it into squares and freeze it before serving. —Alyce Dubisar, North Bend, Oregon

Slow-Cooker Tropical Orange Cake

Inspired by the fruity tropical flavors of my all-time favorite yogurt, this makes for a fresh, fun and comforting treat. Try it for a beautiful dessert that is ridiculously easy to prepare! —Lisa Renshaw, Kansas City, Missouri

Lemon-Blueberry Pound Cake

From the Recipe Creator: Pair a slice of this moist lemon-blueberry cake with a scoop of vanilla ice cream. It's a staple at our family barbecues. —Rebecca Little, Park Ridge, Illinois

From the Recipe Creator: This moist cake with cream cheese frosting is the best I've ever eaten. It's so simple, too, because it uses two jars of baby food instead of fresh carrots that need to be grated. —Jeanette McKenna, Vero Beach, Florida

This cake is inventive and yet familiar. Be sure to use a springform pan so you can easily remove it from the cake. If it breaks while you're transferring it to the serving plate, just push the pieces back together, pressing gently. —Stella Obenian, Porter Ranch, California

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Taste Test: Reposado Tequila

Paul Clarke · Imbibe Magazine

Our March/April 2026 issue dives deep into the world of tequila. If you're on your own exploration of the category, reposado tequila offers a good starting point. Under tequila's regulations, a reposado must be matured in an oak container for a minimum of 60 days. Some reposados may be aged up to a year (after its one-year birthday, the tequila shifts categories and can be considered an añejo). This relatively brief aging period (reposado simply means "rested") can preserve a tequila's core aromas and flavors of agave, while giving it touches of caramel, vanilla, and baking spice. Here are a few worth checking out.

Produced at the La Alteña distillery in Jalisco's highlands, El Tesoro is now overseen by Jenny Camarena, an Imbibe 75 alum for 2026 and the granddaughter of renowned tequilero Don Felipe Camarena. Aged for between nine and 11 months in American ex-bourbon casks, El Tesoro is Exhibit A of what a reposado tequila can be. The aroma is filled with notes of bright fruits and honey. And the flavor is agave-forward, with touches of butterscotch and spice. \$69.96, astorwines.com

Today's tequila producers are increasingly adventurous with their approaches to aging. Mijenta's reposado spends around six to eight months in wood, using a combination of American white oak, cherry, and acacia casks. This approach enables the tequila to show off its bright floral fragrances, along with deeper characteristics of vanilla and citrus. In the glass, there's a depth of cooked agave, honey, and cocoa. \$69.99, mijenta-tequila.com

While most tequila hails from the Mexican state of Jalisco, tequila's legally recognized region stretches into several adjacent states. Chinaco is produced in the state of Tamaulipas, at the family-owned La Gonzaleña distillery. Aged for 11 months in French and English oak barrels that were previously used for aging Scotch whisky, Chinaco reposado is ripe with aromas and flavors of fresh citrus and stone fruit, with a subtle resonance of oak and a gentle spiciness on the finish. \$61.99, reservebar.com

First introduced in 2022, Paladar is produced by the Orendain family at the El Llano distillery (the same family and distillery behind Tequila Arette) in the city center of Tequila. Paladar's reposado is made using fully mature seven-year-old agaves from the distillery's own fields, and is fermented in open-top wooden vats before being distilled and then aged for four months in ex-bourbon casks. This reposado is rich with characteristics of cooked agave and citrus, with a savory minerality balanced by bright aromas of flowers and stone fruit. \$66.99, paladartequila.com

This tequila from the El Sabino distillery in the Jalisco highlands is made from agave cooked in masonry ovens and crushed using a tahona. Matured for 12 weeks in barrels that previously held American whiskey, Zumbador's reposado has an elegant depth of cooked fruit and butter-

scotch, with flavors of cinnamon, vanilla, and agave. \$29.99, zumbadortequila.com

The post Taste Test: Reposado Tequila appeared first on Imbibe Magazine .

Aged for between nine and 11 months in American ex-bourbon casks, El Tesoro is Exhibit A of what a reposado tequila can be.

Paul Clarke

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Moving From Moment.js To The JS Temporal API

Joe Attardi · Smashing Magazine

Almost any kind of application written in JavaScript works with times or dates in some capacity. In the beginning, this was limited to the built-in Date API. This API includes basic functionality, but is quite limited in what it can do.

Third-party libraries like Moment.js, and later built-in APIs such as the Intl APIs and the new Temporal API, add much greater flexibility to working with times and dates.

The Rise And Fall Of Moment.js

Moment.js is a JavaScript library with powerful utilities for working with times and dates. It includes missing features from the basic Date API, such as time zone manipulation, and makes many common operations simpler. Moment also includes functions for formatting dates and times. It became a widely used library in many different applications.

However, Moment also had its share of issues. It's a large library, and can add significantly to an application's bundle size. Because the library doesn't support tree shaking (a feature of modern bundlers that can remove unused parts of libraries), the entire Moment library is included even if you only use one or two of its functions.

Another issue with Moment is the fact that the objects it creates are mutable. Calling certain functions on a Moment object has side effects and mutates the value of that object. This can lead to unexpected behavior or bugs.

In 2020, the maintainers of Moment decided to put the library into maintenance mode. No new feature development is being done, and the maintainers recommend against using it for new projects.

There are other JavaScript date libraries, such as date-fns, but there's a new player in town, an API built directly into JavaScript: Temporal. It's a new standard that fills in the holes of the original Date API as well as solves some of the limitations found in Moment and other libraries.

What Is Temporal?

Temporal is a new time and date API being added to the ECMAScript standard, which defines modern JavaScript. As of March 2026, it has reached Stage 4 of the TC39 process (the committee that oversees proposals and additions to the JavaScript language), and will be included in the next version of the ECMAScript specification. It has already been implemented in several browsers: Chrome 144+ and Firefox 139+, with Safari expected to follow soon. A polyfill is also available for unsupported browsers and Node.js.

The Temporal API creates objects that, generally, represent moments in time. These can be full-time and date stamps in a given time zone, or they can be a generic instance of “wall

clock” time without any time zone or date information. Some of the main features of Temporal include:

Times with or without dates. A Temporal object can represent a specific time on a specific date, or a time without any date information. A specific date, without a time, can also be represented.

Time zone support. Temporal objects are fully time zone aware and can be converted across different time zones. Moment supports time zones, too, but it requires the additional moment-timezone library.

Immutability. Once a Temporal object is created, it cannot be changed. Time arithmetic or time zone conversions do not modify the underlying object. Instead, they generate a new Temporal object.

1-based indexing. A common source of bugs with the Date API (as well as with Moment) is that months are zero-indexed. This means that January is month 0, rather than month 1 as we all understand in real life. Temporal fixes this by using 1-based indexing — January is month 1.

It's built into the browser. Since Temporal is an API in the browser itself, it adds nothing to your application's bundle size.

It's also important to note that the Date API isn't going away. While Temporal supersedes this API, it is not being removed or deprecated. Many applications would break if browsers suddenly removed the Date API. However, also keep in mind that Moment is now considered a legacy project in maintenance mode.

In the rest of the article, we'll look at some “recipes” for migrating Moment-based code to the new Temporal API. Let's start refactoring!

Creating Date And Time Objects

Before we can manipulate dates and times, we have to create objects representing them. To create a Moment object representing the current date and time, use the moment function.

```
const now = moment(); console.log(now); // Moment
```

This object can now be formatted or manipulated as needed.

```
// convert to UTC // warning: This mutates the Moment object and puts it in UTC mode! console.log(now.utc()); // Moment
```

```
// print a formatted string - note that it's using the UTC time now console.log(now.format('MM/DD/YYYY hh:mm:ss a')); // 02/19/2026 02:27:07 am
```

The key thing to remember about Moment is that a Moment object always includes information about the time and the date. If you only need to work with time information, this is

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standard-article(title: [This Two-Minute Trick Turns Brie Into Crispy Chips], author: [Lindsay Parrill], source-name: [Taste of Home], images: (), paragraphs: ([Like any good millennial, I love a charcuterie board. Arranging crackers and bread slices just so, tucking in little bowls of jam and slicing fruit at just the right angle feels so satisfying. There are all sorts of charcuterie combos , and it makes ordinary snacks feel a little more special. It's part cooking, part art project and, most importantly, part excuse to hover near cheese.], [I'm always looking for fun ways to incorporate cheese on snack boards , so when I saw people on social media turning sliced Brie into crispy chips, I was stunned.], [What is the Brie chip trick?], [The Brie chip trick involves using a microwave to turn slices of creamy Brie cheese into puffed crisps.], [When I first saw this, I thought the cheese would surely melt into a puddle. Instead, it puffs, lightly browns and sets into something like homemade chips. The texture lands somewhere between a cheese crisp and a cracker, and it retains its unmistakable buttery flavor.], [In all my cheese-adoring life, I've never once looked at a wheel of Brie and thought, this should be a chip —but here we are. They come out of the microwave looking a little quirky, but we don't judge cheese on its appearance here!], [How do you make Brie chips?], [Start with a firm, standard Brie —something that still holds its shape when sliced. If it's too soft or overly creamy, it's more likely to melt than crisp and puff.], [Line a microwave-safe plate with parchment (without it, things get sticky fast). Slice the cheese into thin pieces, and space them out on the plate so they have room to spread.], [Microwave until the slices puff up and turn somewhat golden. Depending on your microwave, this usually takes around two minutes. Mine hit that perfect point right at the two-minute mark, but it's worth keeping an eye on them the first time you try it. Once they're done, let them cool completely. This is where the magic happens. They firm up and turn crisp as they sit.], [To serve, add them to a charcuterie board alongside honey, jam and fruit, or layer them into a sandwich. You could also cut them into smaller pieces and turn them into cheesy croutons for your

standard-article(title: [1 Unstoppable Quantum Computing Stock to Buy Before It Soars 200%, According to 1 Wall Street Analyst], author: [Keithen Drury], source-name: [The Motley Fool], images: (), paragraphs: ([The quantum computing sector is a great place to find stocks that have the potential to deliver massive returns. However, if one of these companies comes out with a poor testing result or loses a major client, the investment thesis for it can collapse overnight, sending the stock price tumbling.], [My favorite stock in this space is IonQ (NYSE: IONQ) . The company has taken the lead in quantum computing accuracy – and that's key, as error reduction and error correction are the two central problems that must be solved before the technology can start being widely deployed. Analyst John McPeake of Rosenblatt Securities has a \$100 price target on the stock, which means he thinks it could triple from here in the next year.], [So, should investors buy the stock now?], [Continue reading],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 134, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [The Many Falls], author: [Stu Davidson], source-name: [Stuck in Customs], images: (), paragraphs: ([Daily Photo – The Many Falls], [One thing (of many good things) that New Zealand does is create and well maintain walking tracks. They're all over the place on the South Island and even from the middle of a town or city you're often only a few minutes from the beginning of a trail that will take you into a beautiful, serene environment where you'll barely see another human. The paths often cross little streams and regularly pass by lovely waterfalls like this one. Great for popping your shoes off and cooling down some tired feet on the way back.], [Date Taken 2025-03-23 12:50:22], [Camera ILCE-7CR], [Exposure Time 1/25], [Aperture 16], [ISO 320], [Focal Length 24.0 mm], [Flash Off, Did not fire], [The post The Many Falls appeared first on Stuck in Customs .],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 158, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

favorite salad.], [Of course, you might also do what I did and eat nearly half a wheel of Brie in less than five minutes, which, for the record, is apparently not the serving size listed on the package.], [Related:], [I Tried the Viral ‘Sour Fruit’ Trend, and It Changed My Mind About Sour Foods], [This Unexpected Ingredient Makes Popcorn Irresistible], [I Learned This Cutting Board Trick in Culinary School, and I Still Use It Every Day], [The post This Two-Minute Trick Turns Brie Into Crispy Chips appeared first on Taste of Home .],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 469, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

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Alphabet Just Introduced Its Newest AI Advantage, and It’s Another Reason to Buy the Stock

Geoffrey Seiler · The Motley Fool

Alphabet (NASDAQ: GOOGL) (NASDAQ: GOOG) has already proven itself to be one of the most innovative companies in the area of artificial intelligence (AI). The company has developed one of the best AI models with Gemini, and it’s a clear leader in AI video generation and image generation with Veo3 and Nano Banana. In fact, OpenAI recently shut down its competing AI video-generating app Sora, essentially ceding the market to Alphabet.

Meanwhile, the company is also at the forefront of custom AI chips with its tensor processing units (TPUs). It developed these chips with the help of Broadcom more than a decade ago, and it has built an entire hardware and software ecosystem around them that not only provides optimal performance but gives it a huge structural cost edge. With its TPUs, Alphabet can train Gemini and run inference at a much lower cost than competitors that largely rely on graphics processing units (GPUs) from Nvidia . This is just an enormous advantage that grows over time as more and more computing power is required for AI.

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ANALYSIS

IN BRIEF

Bob King, Sky & Telescope: As the comet prepares for its perilous perihelion passage, we look at what to expect.

The post Latest News on the Kreutz Sungrazing Comet C/2026 A1 MAPS appeared first on Sky & Telescope .

Jan Valdez, The Kitchn: Crispy potatoes and a creamy garlic Parmesan sauce are one of my favorite combinations, and this recipe brings both together in the easiest way. I cook the potatoes in a single skillet until they’re golden brown, crisp on the outside, and perfectly tender inside — no oven required. It’s a method I rely on when I want a hearty side dish that also frees up the oven for something bigger, like an Easter baked ham or prime rib roast. [READ MORE...](#)

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